

Crime and Detection

A tubby, chilli-eating, brainy private investigator enlivens a mystery



THE CASE OF THE MISSING SERVANT
by TARQUIN HALL
Mushkin
Price: Rs 425
Pages: 312

| By Bunny Suraiya |

Vish Puri is the founder, owner and managing director of Most Private Investigators Ltd. ("Confidentiality is our Watchword"), a Delhi-based company which boasts a 100 per cent success rate. Fondly nicknamed Chubby by his prescient parents, Puri is admittedly rather portly, 51 years old, addicted to green chillies and, on account of a somewhat short left leg, forced to wear orthopaedic shoes with rubber soles that squeak embarrassingly on the high-gloss floors of elite establishments.

But lest you should infer that he is a figure of fun, Puri is a brain-box whose amazing powers of deduction would make Sherlock Holmes eat his deerstalker, feather and all. He is ably assisted by his core team: Tubelight, scion of a family of hereditary thieves and adept at picking locks; computer and electronic whiz, Flush (so named for being the first person with a flushing toilet in his village), and Facecream, a feisty Nepali beauty accomplished in working undercover as a hooker or infiltrating suspects' homes as a domestic servant. Also bent on helping Puri is his mother, the redoubtable Mummy, a retired school principal and no slouch in the detection business herself, who conducts clandestine investigations despite her son's strenuous objections that "Mummies are not detectives".

Most of Puri's cases involve matrimonial inquiries where he is hired by either the bride's or the groom's side to determine whether the other party is morally, financially and socially sound. Puri, a righteous citizen, with deep-rooted

family values (he loves his devoted wife, Rumpi, and his three daughters to distraction), deprecates such investigations, but appreciates their necessity. As he points out in a letter to *The Times of India*, "Many thousands of males and females are working in call centres... side by side and they are becoming attached and going in for one-night stands," and he carries out his briefs efficiently, if not enthusiastically. But when an honest lawyer, dedicated to cleansing the legal system, is accused of murdering his maidservant in Jaipur, the plot thickens with gratifying rapidity. And when Puri himself, while tending to his beloved pots of green chillies on his roof, is shot at, the bullets narrowly missing his head, the ingenious investigator gets to prove his mettle, and bring his investigations to a satisfying denouement.

In addition to having created a marvellous literary personage in Puri (think Holmes, Rumpole and Jeeves), Tarquin Hall has a fine grasp of the nuances of north Indian life and lingo, as well as an in-depth knowledge on a wide range of subjects. Such as the workings of courtrooms in India, the hardships of Adivasi life in Jharkhand, the appalling conditions in local jails, corruption at top levels among the police. The list could go on.

But throughout it all, the tubby figure of Puri stands tall above the sleaze. A man of principle, intelligence, and with a heart as soft as butter, Puri is given to small, harmless vanities ("I was on the cover of *India Today* magazine. It's a distinction no other Indian detective has achieved till date") which in no way detract from—indeed they can be said to add to—the irresistible charm of this new entrant into the pantheon of luminous fictional characters. I look forward eagerly to the next Vish Puri book. And the one after that.



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